

- RAG Learning

1.1 Individual and Social Variation

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 1 Language Variation

Paper 1 asks you to analyse how English varies across individuals, social groups, time and geography. This topic focuses on **individual variation** (idiolect), **social variation** (sociolect, class, gender, age, ethnicity) and the concepts of **prestige** and **accommodation** that describe how speakers move between varieties. Key theorists: Labov, Trudgill, Milroy, Cheshire, Petyt, Giles, Kerswill, Eckert & McConnell-Ginet.

1.1.1 Core Terminology

Term	Definition	Example
Idiolect	Unique linguistic profile of an individual speaker	A friend's distinctive slang + intonation pattern
Sociolect	Variety associated with a social group	Teenage sociolect using "bare", "peng"
Dialect	Variety with distinctive lexis, grammar and often pronunciation	Geordie, Scouse, Cockney
Accent	Pronunciation patterns of a speaker or group	Cockney, RP, West Country
Register	Level of formality/appropriateness to context	Academic essay vs WhatsApp to friend

Standard English	The dialect recognised for formal, educational and official use	The grammar taught in schools; the form of most written prose
RP (Received Pronunciation)	A historically high-prestige British accent, not tied to a specific region	Traditional BBC news presenter accent

Exam Tip: Standard English is a DIALECT (vocabulary + grammar). RP is an ACCENT (pronunciation). You can speak Standard English in any regional accent. Confusing them is a common error — Edexcel examiners explicitly reward candidates who distinguish them.

1.1.2 Individual Variation — Idiolect

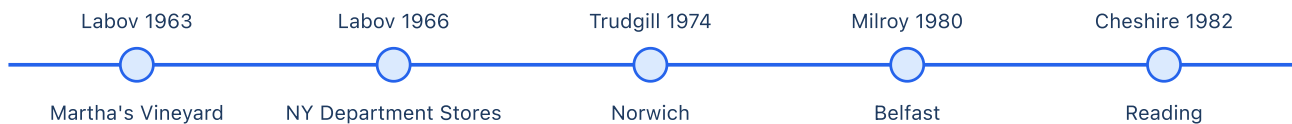
No two speakers are identical. Each person's speech reflects a combination of their family upbringing, regional exposure, educational background, peer groups, age and personal preferences. Idiolect includes:

- **Lexical preferences** — favoured words, catchphrases, slang.
- **Syntactic tendencies** — preferred sentence structures, tag questions, discourse markers.
- **Pronunciation quirks** — individual vowel qualities, stress patterns.
- **Prosodic patterns** — pitch range, tempo, rhythm.
- **Pragmatic style** — directness, hedging habits, politeness default.

Every idiolect is composed of multiple sociolects operating together: a young professional from Yorkshire might blend features of Northern phonology, professional register, youth slang and family speech patterns.

1.1.3 Social Variation — The Classic Studies

Key Sociolinguistic Studies



Labov — New York Department Stores (1966)

Labov elicited the phrase "fourth floor" from shop assistants in three stores of different social prestige (Saks — high, Macy's — mid, S. Klein — low), in both casual and careful (repeated) speech. He measured the frequency of post-vocalic /r/.

Findings: /r/ increased with store prestige AND with careful speech. Lower-middle-class Macy's staff **hypercorrected** — producing more /r/ than upper-middle-class Saks staff in careful speech. Established that linguistic variables correlate systematically with social variables and speaker style.

Labov — Martha's Vineyard (1963)

Labov studied centralisation of diphthongs on Martha's Vineyard. Younger islanders who wanted to distance themselves from mainland summer visitors *centralised more*. Showed variation tied to **identity** — language performs group membership.

Trudgill — Norwich (1974)

Peter Trudgill interviewed speakers across five social classes on variables including /ɪŋ/ ("walking" vs "walkin'"). He also used self-report tests.

- Standard forms increased with class and formality.
- Women used more standard forms than men of the same class.
- Men *over-reported* non-standard use — **covert prestige**.
- Women *over-reported* standard use — **overt prestige**.

Milroy — Belfast (1980)

Lesley Milroy measured **network strength** — density (interconnectedness) and multiplexity (roles per contact). High-density networks correlated with more local vernacular use; loose networks

with more standard forms. Shifted attention from class categories to social networks as explanatory variables.

Cheshire — Reading (1982)

Jenny Cheshire studied adolescent peer groups in Reading. Non-standard grammatical features (e.g. "we was", multiple negation) correlated with membership in tough peer groups — **covert prestige** operating through peer norms.

Petyt — Bradford

Documented H-dropping in Bradford, confirming clear correlation with social class.

Kerswill — Dialect Levelling

Paul Kerswill showed that mobility, media and education are reducing distinctive local features in UK English — producing more regionally levelled varieties. However new varieties (MLE) also emerge, so levelling is not uniformity.

1.1.4 Prestige — Overt and Covert

- **Overt prestige** — publicly valued standard forms. A newsreader using RP is performing overt prestige.
- **Covert prestige** — hidden prestige attached to non-standard forms valued within a group. A builder using local vernacular on-site is performing covert prestige.

Both forces act on every speaker. Overt drives convergence towards the standard in formal contexts; covert drives retention of vernacular features in peer contexts. Most speakers **style-shift** fluidly between them.

Applied Example: A Year 13 student might use Standard English and formal prosody in an interview (overt prestige) but switch to MLE features with peers afterwards (covert prestige). Neither is "correct" — they perform different identities and relationships.

1.1.5 Accommodation Theory — Giles

Howard Giles's **Communication Accommodation Theory** describes how speakers adjust their style:

- **Convergence** — moving speech style *towards* the listener, typically to build rapport or manage social distance.
- **Divergence** — moving speech style *away* from the listener, often to assert identity or power.
- **Maintenance** — keeping one's own style — neither converging nor diverging.

Accommodation interacts with prestige: convergence may be towards overt prestige (job interview) or covert prestige (fitting in with peers). Divergence may be used to emphasise regional pride, resist authority, or mark out ethnic or generational identity.

1.1.6 Social Class and Language

Class has been a dominant variable in UK sociolinguistics. Important concepts:

- **Class-stratified variation** — variables like /ing/, H-dropping, t-glottalisation and double negation correlate with class.
- **Hypercorrection** — aspirant groups overshooting the prestige norm (Labov's NYC finding).
- **Bernstein's restricted / elaborated codes** — controversial proposal that working-class speech is "restricted" (context-bound) and middle-class "elaborated" (decontextualised). Widely critiqued as a deficit view. Labov's work on AAVE shows vernacular speech is rule-governed and expressive. Modern linguistics treats this as code *difference*, not deficit.

1.1.7 Occupation, Age and Other Variables

- **Occupational lexis** — field-specific jargon, acronyms, genres (medical, legal, IT).
- **Age** — variation across generations; younger speakers often lead sound change.
- **Anti-language** (Halliday) — a variety used by marginal groups to construct an alternative identity.
- **Style-shifting** — the same speaker adjusting register across contexts.

- **Idiolect** — every speaker is individual; within-group variation is huge.

1.1.8 Community of Practice

Penelope Eckert and Sally McConnell-Ginet (1992) proposed **community of practice** as an alternative to static class categories. A community of practice is a group that coheres around shared practices and goals — a sports team, a school clique, a workplace. Members develop shared repertoires including linguistic ones.

Benefit: allows intersectional analysis — speakers belong to multiple communities, each contributing to their idiolect. Moves beyond the idea that a speaker "belongs to" a class or gender in a simple way.

1.1.9 Standard English and RP — Sociohistorical Status

Standard English and RP are historically contingent. Standard English emerged from the East-Midland dialect used by Chaucer and reinforced by printing (Caxton, 1476) and Johnson's dictionary (1755). RP emerged in the 19th century with the rise of the public school system.

Neither is linguistically superior. Their prestige reflects the social groups whose speech became the standard. Treating other varieties as "incorrect" is a social judgement dressed as linguistic fact. An A-level answer that distinguishes linguistic fact from sociohistorical prestige scores well on AO2 and AO3.

1.1.10 How to Analyse Variation Texts at A-Level

1. Identify the **variety**: which region, class, age, gender, ethnicity or community?
2. Identify **specific features**: phonology (H-dropping, t-glottalisation), lexis (dialect words, slang), grammar (non-standard forms), prosody.
3. Link to **named studies**: Labov, Trudgill, Milroy, Cheshire, Petyt, Kerswill.
4. Apply **concepts**: overt/covert prestige, accommodation, network density, community of practice.

5. Engage with **attitudes**: how is the variety typically perceived? What ideological work does this do?
6. Evaluate: avoid deficit framing; acknowledge the rule-governed nature of all varieties.

Exam Tip: Edexcel Paper 1 pairs two texts with a time gap. Your analysis must move across individual, social and (if relevant) temporal dimensions of variation, integrating multiple named studies. Top-band AO2 requires PRECISE reference to studies; AO3 requires engagement with context.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **idiolect, sociolect, dialect, accent, register, Standard English, RP, overt / covert prestige, hypercorrection, accommodation (convergence / divergence / maintenance), network density, community of practice, levelling, restricted / elaborated code, style-shifting, jargon, anti-language**. Studies: **Labov (NY, Martha's Vineyard), Trudgill (Norwich), Milroy (Belfast), Cheshire (Reading), Petyt (Bradford), Kerswill (levelling), Giles (Accommodation), Eckert & McConnell-Ginet (community of practice)**.